



Merit Education Group

Unit 1: Expressions — Family Overview

Algebra 1 • What Your Student Is Learning

Dear Families,

Welcome to Unit 1 of Algebra 1! In this unit, your student will explore the foundations of algebraic expressions — what they are, how to write them, and how to simplify and evaluate them. This unit builds the essential skills needed for all future work in algebra, including solving equations, working with functions, and modeling real-world situations.

What Your Student Will Learn

By the end of this unit, students will be able to:

- Write algebraic expressions from verbal phrases and real-world scenarios
- Identify parts of an expression: variables, constants, coefficients, and terms
- Evaluate expressions by substituting specific values for variables
- Combine like terms to simplify expressions
- Apply the order of operations (GEMDAS) correctly

Key Vocabulary

Variable	A symbol (usually a letter) that represents an unknown number
Constant	A fixed value that does not change
Coefficient	The number multiplied by a variable
Expression	A combination of numbers, variables, and operations
Like Terms	Terms that have the same variable raised to the same power

How You Can Support at Home

- Ask your student to describe what a variable represents in everyday situations — for example, “If we don’t know how many miles we’ll drive, what letter could stand for that number?”
- Practice the order of operations with simple numeric expressions like $3 + 2 \times 5$ or $(8 - 3)^2$.

- Encourage your student to keep a vocabulary journal with the key terms from each lesson.
- Review homework together and ask your student to explain their steps out loud.

Coming Up Next

After mastering expressions, students will move on to solving one-step and two-step equations. They will use their understanding of variables and inverse operations to find unknown values — a key skill for everything that follows in Algebra 1.

Sincerely,

The MEG Curriculum Team